Common Sense

Thomas Paine · January 1776 · excerpts

Source: Project Gutenberg, gutenberg.org/ebooks/147; original pamphlet, Philadelphia, 1776.

Published anonymously in Philadelphia in January 1776, Thomas Paine's pamphlet sold an estimated 120,000 copies in three months — extraordinary for a colonial population of about 2.5 million. Paine argued in plain language that reconciliation with Britain was impossible and that monarchy itself was illegitimate. The pamphlet helped shift colonial opinion from protest to independence in the months before the Declaration.

Connect: How does Paine's attack on monarchy build on the colonists' grievances from Class 2?

Key Passages

On monarchy

> There is something exceedingly ridiculous in the composition of monarchy; it first excludes a man from the means of information, yet empowers him to act in cases where the highest judgment is required.

On reconciliation

> Everything that is right or natural pleads for separation. The blood of the slain, the weeping voice of nature cries, 'TIS TIME TO PART.

On America's destiny

> We have it in our power to begin the world over again. A situation, similar to the present, hath not happened since the days of Noah until now. The birthday of a new world is at hand.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice: Identify ONE specific piece of evidence from Common Sense and explain how it advanced the cause of independence.

2. Why was Paine's plain, accessible style strategically important in 1776?

3. How does Paine's argument about monarchy connect to the Declaration of Independence six months later?